when considered against the fact that, in the eight previous Tests at the Bullring, the team batting first had only once passed 280. In truth, it was a missed opportunity that would come back to bite us. We wanted to be positive and take the game to England, but too many of us got ourselves in and got ourselves out. I was as guilty as anyone, racing to 36 from 40 balls and then being caught behind wafting on the leg side. All 11 of us reached double figures but no one passed 50.

KG raced in again when England started batting, and we seemed to be getting on top when we had them 22 for two and then 91 for four, but Root scored an excellent century and, with Stokes and Bairstow scoring valuable middle-order runs once again, the touring side reached 323, securing a lead of 10 runs.

We were well in the Test just before lunch on the third day, but, within the space of three crazy hours, it was all over: the match was lost, the series was lost and the English players were celebrating. Our fragility had been exposed yet again, and Stuart Broad had demonstrated his ability to win a Test with one spell. The fast bowler took our top five wickets for one run in a devastating six-over spell, causing a collapse from 25 for no wicket to 35 for five. I was caught behind off the inside edge for 0. Faf resisted for just under two hours and KG hit a couple of boundaries as we scrambled to 83 all out, our second-lowest total in a Test since readmission. England knocked off the 74 runs required for victory within 23 overs, and we were done.

Defeat meant that, according to the ICC rankings, we were formally replaced as the No. 1 Test team in the world by India, and many in the media began to predict the decline of the Proteas.

'How much have you missed Dale Steyn in this series?' one journalist asked at the press conference.

'We miss Dale, we miss Vern, we miss Kallis as well,' I replied, 'but this is the team we have and this is the team I believe in. We created opportunities here, but failed to take them. It is up to the 11 players picked for the